INTERVIEW

"MARATHAS WILL VOTE TO DEFEAT THE OPPRESSORS"

Maratha leader Manoj Jarange-Patil tells *Dhaval S. Kulkarni* that the community will support anyone who backs their OBC quota demand. Edited excerpts:



MANDAR DEODHAR

Q. Why did you decide to pull out from contesting polls?
I want to sustain the movement (for quotas) rather than enter politics. There was a risk of losing had we contested on the support of just one caste. It would have been an emotional blow...the community would have been taunted that 60 million Marathas could not elect 4-5 MLAs.

Q. Who will you support in the assembly election?
We are not supporting anyone. The community will vote on election day for those who support us and to defeat those who have oppressed us.

Q. Is this a reference to the BJP?
The samaj knows everything, whether it is the BJP or Devendra Fadnavis or anyone else.

Q. Will the Jarange factor work again in Marathwada like in the LS poll?
It worked in all Maharashtra, not just in Marathwada. If Fadnavis's acolytes talk against me, I will hit the trail and make things difficult for them. They must not cross the line.

Q. What are your expectations from the next government?
I have no expectations from the Mahayuti or MVA other than reservations for the Marathas. I am firm on my position, we'll ensure we get it.

Q. What do you think of the state government granting Marathas 10 per cent quotas?
They can give this 10 per cent to their own caste or to others. We want quotas from the OBC category. This reservation is not legally sustainable and yet they keep harping on it.

beyond Marathwada too.

"The community is with *dada* and not with any party," claims Suresh Kale from Wadigodri village, some 5 km from Antarwali-Sarathi. "Things will move where *dada* points his finger... as in the Lok Sabha election," says Sachin Havle Patil from Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar. Scratch under the surface and the causes of the unrest reveal themselves. Agrarian distress, lack of industrialisation, unaffordable private sector education, and the attraction of stable government jobs are among the prime drivers of the Maratha quota protests (see box: *Marathwada's Pain Points*) and the OBC counter-mobilisation against it.

Fraying 'Madhav' pattern

In the 1980s, the BJP, which was then seen as a party of Shetjis (merchants) and Bhatjis (Brahmins), cultivated a base among OBC groups like the Malis (gardeners), Dhangars (shepherds) and Vanjaris. This led to the emergence of the powerful 'Madhav' pattern and the rise of saffron OBC leaders like the late deputy CM Gopinath Munde to take on the dominant Maratha-Kunbi caste complex. Marathwada, and especially Beed, where Munde hailed from, was seen as the crucible of the Madhav experiment, and hence the epicentre of the Maratha versus OBC conflict.



"If there is a demand (for quotas), there will be retaliation. Both will happen in parallel (implying OBC mobilisation against Marathas)"

DHANANJAY MUNDE *(Mahayuti)*
NCP leader and agriculture minister

The Maratha-Kunbis are said to account for 31.5 per cent of Maharashtra's population, while the OBCs number over 52 per cent. However, the Kunbis, who have significant numbers in Konkan and Vidarbha, where they may not be endogamous with the Marathas, are already in the OBC category—as are those with Maratha-Kunbi or Kunbi-Maratha records. More realistic surmises put the population of Marathas, sans the Kunbis, at 12-16 per cent. While it is relatively easier to mobilise the caste-conscious Marathas on issues like quotas, the lack of a singular, overarching OBC identity that transcends caste/ religious lines makes it difficult for the backwards across 450 communities across Maharashtra to mobilise to that extent.

While the BJP has tried to rally the OBCs—Fadnavis claims his party has